

ELEPHANTS



THE AFRICAN AND ASIAN elephants are the only two living species of a once much larger family that was found on every continent. The African elephant is the largest land mammal, but despite its size and power it is a gentle creature. Elephants are highly intelligent, very sociable animals, that live in close family units. The African and Asian elephants are descended from different ancestors; the Asian elephant is more closely related to the mammoth than to the African elephant.

Teeth

The elephant has only four teeth, one in each quarter of the jaw. Each tooth is about 30 cm (12 in) long. As one wears down, another pushes in from behind. This can happen only six times, after which the supply of teeth is exhausted. Without teeth, the elephant can no longer eat, so dies of starvation.

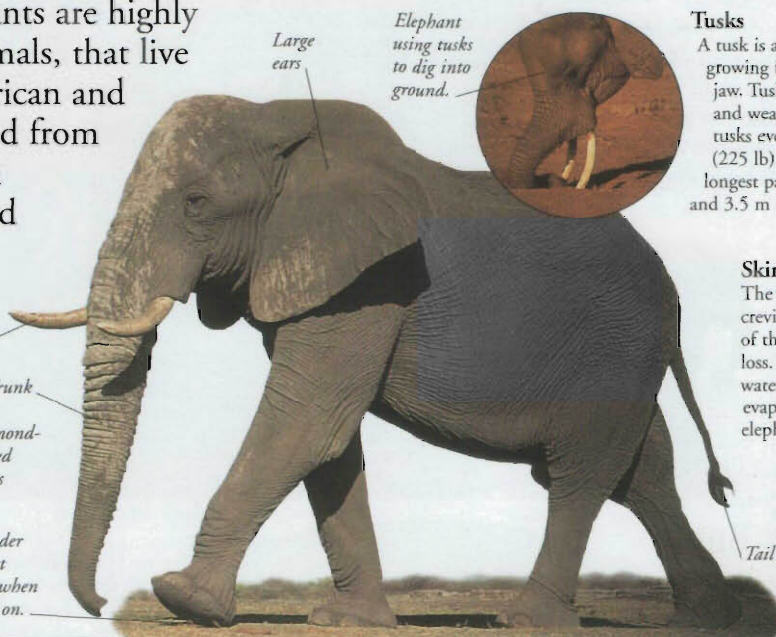


Tusks

Trunk

Diamond-shaped ridges

Pads under large feet expand when trodden on.



Large ears

Elephant using tusks to dig into ground.

Tusks

A tusk is a specialized type of tooth, growing from either side of the upper jaw. Tusks are used mainly as tools and weapons. The heaviest pair of tusks ever recorded weighed 102 kg (225 lb) and 109 kg (240 lb). The longest pair measured 3.35 m (11 ft) and 3.5 m (11 ft 5 in) in length.

Skin

The skin is very wrinkled. Deep crevices increase the surface area of the skin, and allow greater heat loss. The crevices also help to trap water which then takes longer to evaporate, and helps to keep the elephant cooler for longer.



Tail

Trunk

The elephant's trunk is highly flexible and serves much the same functions as a human arm and hand. It combines great strength with delicacy, and is so versatile that it can pluck a single leaf as easily as it can lift a heavy log. Because the elephant has a trunk it does not need to lower its head while feeding, thus allowing it to remain alert. The trunk also allows the elephant to reach high above its head to browse on leaves that are out of most other animals' reach.



The elephant uses its trunk to feed.

Fingers are used to hold objects.

Nostrils

Located at the tip of the trunk, the elephant's nostrils can be raised high above its head, like a periscope, and turned in any direction to pick up traces of scent carried on the wind.

The elephant relies on its sense of smell more than its other senses. While swimming, the trunk may be lifted above the surface of the water, and used as a snorkel if the elephant gets out of its depth.

Picking up scent on the wind



Fingers

As well as the nostrils, the tip of the trunk has fleshy "fingers". The African species has two opposing fingers, but the Asian elephant has only one which it uses to grip against the wide underside of the trunk. Fingers enable the elephant to perform precise movements and pick up very small objects.

Upper finger

Lower finger

Fingers of the African elephant trunk

Elephant reaching up with its trunk.

Small rounded ears

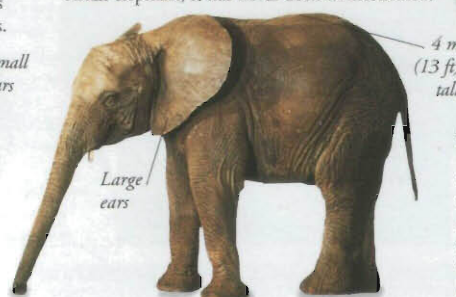


African forest elephant

The forest elephant is a smaller subspecies of the African bush elephant, with smaller, more rounded ears. It does not need such large ears to help it keep cool, as it lives in the tropical rainforests of the Congo basin in equatorial Africa. Its tusks are slender and downward pointing.

African bush elephant

The African bush elephant lives in open country and woodland in Africa south of the Sahara. It is larger, with much larger ears and a more concave back than the Asian elephant. Both males and females have tusks. Unlike the Asian elephant, it has never been domesticated.



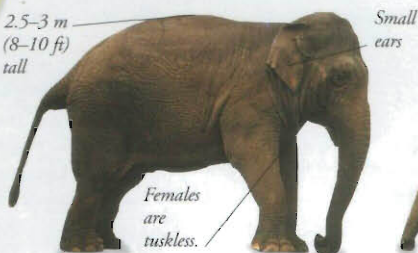
4 m (13 ft) tall

Large ears

Types of elephant

Asian elephant

The Asian elephant, found in forests in India and south-eastern Asia, has been domesticated for at least 2,500 years. It is used for ceremonial purposes and forestry work. Of the 34,000–56,000 elephants remaining in Asia, 10,000 are working animals.



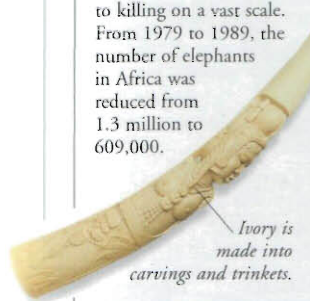
2.5–3 m (8–10 ft) tall

Small ears

Females are tuskless.

Ivory trade

The elephant's only enemy is humans, who kill them for their tusks. In recent years, the demand for ivory has led to killing on a vast scale. From 1979 to 1989, the number of elephants in Africa was reduced from 1.3 million to 609,000.



Ivory is made into carvings and trinkets.